Descartes' Rationalism

This handout will consider Descartes arguments in his 'Meditations on First Philosophy' and show how he attempts with the aid of pure reason (thus as a rationalist) to prove the existence of the self, God and the external world. In other words, the work is a classic example of rationalism, and can be used through the course to as an example to illustrate the claims of rationalism. It will consider Descartes concept of rational intuition and deduction as sources of knowledge.

Meditation I

The aim of Descartes' meditations on first philosophy is to prove the existence of the self, God and the external world. However, what is new about Descartes work, is that it aims to prove the existence of these three concepts on new foundations. This is because the revolution from the Aristotelian to the Copernican understanding of the place of the earth in the solar system, had shown that much of our previous knowledge could not be trusted. With this in mind, Descartes sought to start from scratch and build an edifice of human knowledge that was set on firmer ground.

> 'Some years ago I was struck by the large number of falsehoods that I had accepted as true since my childhood, and by the highly doubtful nature of the whole edifice that I had subsequently based on them. I realised that it was necessary once in the course of my life time to demolish everything and start again from the foundations, if I wanted to establish anything at all in the sciences that was stable and likely to last'.

In order to find this ultimate and solid foundation on which to ground this knowledge, he introduced the three waves of doubt. The three waves of doubt are intended to filter out any beliefs that we have that could be false, even if the likelihood of them being false is minute. It is vital to understand that Descartes is seeking certain knowledge, which means anything that can be doubted he will not consider as true. The three waves of doubt include the argument from

1. Illusion
2. Dreaming
3. Deception

(1) Illusion

The argument from illusion claims that we often suffer illusions from our sense experience which can be known to lead us astray. Descartes claims that since our sense experiences can deceive us, we cannot fully trust them, and given that he is looking for certain knowledge, he decides to put aside the evidence of the senses. He writes that

> 'Whatever I have up till now accepted as most true I have acquired either from the senses or through the senses. But from time to time, I have found that the senses deceive, and it is prudent never to trust completely those who have deceived us even once'.

(2) The Dreaming hypothesis

From undermining our complete truth in our sense experience, Descartes then moves on to the deeper and more problematic attack on our experience. This is the second, wave of doubt, which is founded on the claim, that none of us can know, that at this very moment, we are not dreaming. The argument is quite subtle, however, it is based on the simple claim, that even if we are not always dreaming, we cannot at this very moment know that we are not dreaming, because it is obvious that often we think we are awake when we are in fact asleep, and that since one can have very vivid dreams, it is plausible that at this moment I am in one. Descartes point is made very explicitly,

> 'Yet at the moment my eyes are certainly awake, when I look at this piece of paper; I shake my head and it is not asleep; as I stretch out an feel my hand I do so deliberately, and I know what I am doing. All this would not happen with such distinctness to someone asleep. Indeed! As if I did not remember other occasions when I have been tricked by exactly similar thoughts when I was asleep! As I think about this more carefully, I see plainly that there are never any sure signs by means of which being awake can be distinguished from being asleep. The result is that I begin to feel dazed, and this very feeling only reinforces the notion that I may be asleep.'

The dream hypothesis makes it possible that our experience of our body and the external world is false, because we only need a mind to dream. So, it is possible that I have no 'hands or eyes, or flesh, or blood or senses, but as falsely believing that I have all these things'.

Descartes then considers that even though he may not have knowledge of anything in the world that is composite, and can be studied in the natural sciences, such as 'physics, astronomy and medicine', he may have knowledge of truths of the formal

sciences, such as mathematics and geometry, 'that deal with the simplest and most general things, regardless of whether they exist in nature or not'. At this point Descartes introduces the final wave of doubt which can be labelled the deception argument, or the evil demon thought experiment.



Descartes considers the possibility that he is lying in bed, rather than sitting warming himself by the fire, and he notes that it sometimes happens that he is sure he is awake when in fact he is asleep. He then wonders whether he is at this moment in a dream.

(3) The evil demon

This hypothesis does not only undermine our belief in the physical world including out body, but even in our a priori claims to logical knowledge. He writes,

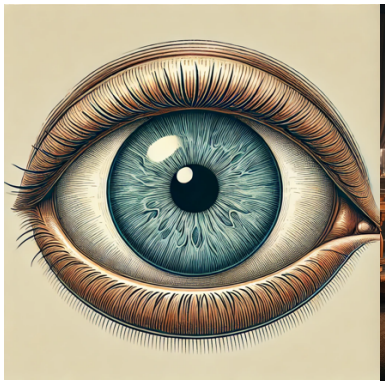
> 'I will suppose that not God, who is supremely good and the source of truth, but rather some malicious demon of the utmost power and cunning has employed all his energies in order to deceive me…'

The following claim is the thought that our current experience is logically compatible with total deception, the falsehood of all our thoughts so that we cannot even think correctly about mathematical or geometrical truths, that even our most basic thoughts about the formal sciences (for example mathematics) such as that 2+2=4 is incorrect. This form of deception does not target our sense-experience or even knowledge of our body and the outside world, but our very ability to think at all. The following table can help us understand the connection between the wave of doubt and the thing doubted. Descartes then writes

> ‘I shall think that the sky, the air, the earth, colours, shapes, sounds are all the delusions of dreams which he has devised to ensnare my judgement. I shall consider myself not to have hands, or eyes, or flesh or blood or senses, but as falsely believing that I have all these things. I shall stubbornly and firmly persist in this meditation; and, even if it is not in my power to know any truth, I shall at least do what is in my power, that is resolutely guard against assenting to any falsehoods, so that the deceiver, however, powerful and cunning he may be, will be unable to impose on me to the slightest degree.’

The table below illustrates the three waves of doubt, and the objects that they bring into doubt. As you can see, the argument from illusion makes us doubt the reliability of our senses. The dream hypothesis, the existence of the external world, and the evil demon hypothesis the reliability of our thoughts.

Wave of doubt	The thing put into question
Wave 1: The argument from illusion.	The trustworthiness of our senses.
Wave 2: The dream hypothesis.	The existence of a physical world and our body.
Wave3: The evil demon.	The truthfulness of our thoughts about mathematics and geometry and thus anything at all.





Descartes three waves of doubt are firstly, of sense perception, secondly, of dreaming and lastly of the evil demon hypothesis.

Meditations II

The second meditation is an absolutely seminal essay, in the history of modern western philosophy. It introduces three important elements of Descartes thinking that will later become significant objects of controversy and debate. They are

(1) The cogito
(2) The status of rational intuition
(3) The concept of substance

This section of the handout will consider all three in turn. But it is important to bear in mind that in some important sense, these three elements rely on each other, because the proof of the cogito and of physical substance as founded in the final analysis on 'rational intuition'.

(1) The Cogito

We are aware that at the end of the first, meditation Descartes has fallen into a state of radical scepticism, where he has had to suspend belief in all the things he previously took for granted. The second meditation can be considered a turning point, where Descartes attempts to show that he *can* have knowledge, but that this

must be built on new foundations. These new foundations are the cogito and rational intuition. At the beginning of the second meditation Descartes writes the following

> '…I have convinced myself that there is nothing in the world, no sky, no earth, no minds, no bodies. Does it follow that I too do not exist?'

Given that Descartes has suspended belief in everything, he naturally extends the sceptical doubt as far as he can, and wonders if he can doubt his own existence. This he comes to believe if impossible. He writes

> 'No: if I convinced myself of something (or thought anything at all) then I certainly existed. But there is a supreme power and cunning who is deliberately and constantly deceiving me. In that case I too undoubtedly exist, if he is deceiving me; and let him deceive me as much as he can, he will never bring it about that I am nothing so long as I think that I am something. So after considering everything very thoroughly, I must finally conclude that this proposition, *I am, I exist*, is necessarily true whenever it is put forward by me or conceived in my mind.'

In other words, in as much as he doubts, then there must be something that is doing the doubting, even if he is totally deceived and knows absolutely nothing, he must exist, as a mind for that to be true. In other words, even if the evil demon hypothesis is correct, that would not touch his existence.

What Descartes claims *is certain*, and incorrigible (unable to be corrected or disputed) – is the phrase '*I am, I exist*' *or* '*Cogito ergo sum*'. It is important to note two things. First, that *thinking itself*, (which for Descartes includes doubting, considering, even wanting) is something of which he is certain, *and it is this*, that grounds 'the assurance

that he exists'.[1] Secondly, the proposition, '*I am, I exist*' is 'self-verifying, in the sense that if anyone asserts the proposition, then the assertion must be true'.

It should be noticed that the phrase 'I am, exist' is not what philosophers call a standard argument. The reason is that an argument involves usually two propositions and a conclusion that follows from it. In this instance, there is no real proposition, and the conclusion is not linked in the usual way. The reason for this, is that this is better understood as an example of *rational intuition* then as an argument from facts to conclusions. In fact, Descartes makes this clear

> 'When someone says, I am *thinking*, therefore I *am*, or I *exist*, he does not conclude his existence from his thought, as if by force of some syllogism, but as a thing which is self-evident: he sees it by a simple inspection of the mind…it is impossible that he should think if he does not exist.'[2]

The key thing to understand is that Descartes *does not presuppose* that 'everything that thinks exists' but rather that 'it is impossible to think without existing'. The truth of the second proposition is an eternal logical truth that does not rely on anything being the case in the world. Williams writes 'Thus the point is that 'in order to think, it is necessary to exist' does not make reference to anything that exists in the world: it is a bare statement of necessity which can, on Descartes view, be intuitively grasped'. In other words, Descartes does not claim that he knows that everything that thinks exists, from some *experience* of thinking things in the world, rather, he knows that *if something is thinking it must exist, by logical alone*, without needing to attend to things out in the world. This is a classic example of rationalist philosophy at work.

(2) The status of rational intuition.

[1] Bernard Williams
[2] Descartes replies VII

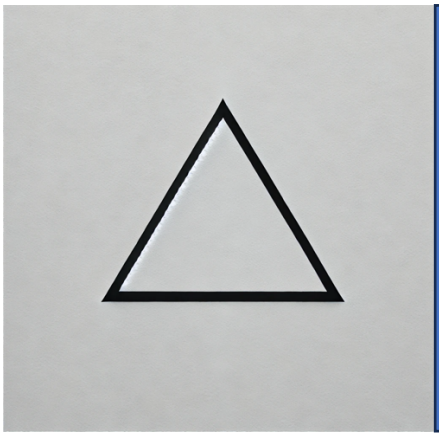
In order to understand what rational intuition is, we need to understand three things.

(1) Clear and distinct ideas

(2) Intuition

(3) Deduction

A clear and distinct idea can be illustrated by the image for example of a triangle. Descartes says of *clear* ideas that '…it is present and accessible to the attentive mind – just as we say that we see something when it is clearly present to the eye's gaze and stimulates it with a sufficient degree of strength and accessibility.' Of *distinctness* he writes that 'if it is sharply separated from all other ideas that every part of it is clear'. So the idea of a triangle would be a good example of a 'clear and distinct idea'.

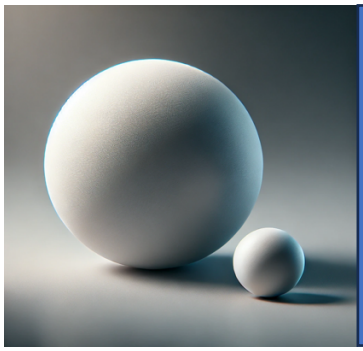


A clear and distinct idea is one that is present and accessible to the attentive mind – just as we say that we see something when it is clearly present to the eye's gaze and stimulates it with a sufficient degree of strength and accessibility.' Of distinctness he writes that 'if it is sharply separated from all other ideas that every part of it is clear'.

Intuition can be understood as the 'immediate grasp of some intellectual matter, where this covers both the grasping of the truth of some proposition, and the grasping of the validity of the inferences: I can see in intuition both that such-and-such is the case, and that one thing follows logically from another'.[3] For example, we can have an intuition from the following clear and distinct ideas. If we perceive the

[3] Bernard Williams

image of one ball next to another, and one is clearly larger than another, we can both intuit both the balls, and their relationship all at once. That is an example of a rational intuition.



We have clear and distinct idea of the large ball, and a clear and distinct idea of the small ball. We can intuit from these clear and distinct idea that 'there is one ball that is larger than another ball'. This would be an example of a rational intuition. The proposition follows immediately from the ideas.

A deduction is the ability to travel from the clear and distinct idea to the conclusion in an instant. A deduction can be of smaller or larger chains of intuitions.

(3) The concept of Substance

To understand the importance of and meaning of rational intuition Descartes will introduce his thought experiment regarding a piece of wax. The thought experiment has two aspects, the first is that it shows how rational intuition enables us to have our most basic knowledge of things such as identity, and the second, is that it will reveal the nature (essence) of physical substance as extension. It is rational intuition that gives us more perfect understanding and knowledge, the other faculties, such as the senses, and imagination cannot do this.

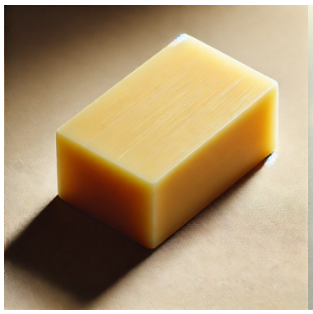
Descartes asks us to consider a piece of wax that has 'just been taken from the honeycomb' he says of it that, 'it has not yet lost the taste of the honey; it retains some of the scent of the flowers from which it was gathered; it's colour, shape and size are plain to see; it is hard cold and can be handled without difficulty'. Descartes then claims that he 'puts the wax beside the fire, and look, the residual taste is eliminated, the smell goes away, the colour changes, the shape is lost, the size

increases; it becomes liquid and hot; you can hardly touch it, and if you strike it, it does not make a sound'.

Descartes then goes on to explain that our senses *cannot be the sources of our knowledge* that the two experiences are of 'one' piece of wax. What the senses told me about the piece of wax have all changed, and yet the wax remains. Descartes considers if our imagination can be the source of our knowledge of the wax as 'one' piece, and he thinks it cannot be our imagination. Even if our imagination helps us graps the ideas that the wax is 'flexible' and 'changeable' our imagination cannot give us an adequate understanding of those concepts, because all the infinite possible changes in a piece of wax cannot be grasped by the imagination. Finally, Descartes makes the following point,

> 'I must therefore admit that the nature of this piece of wax is in no way revealed by my imagination, but is perceived by the mind alone…The perception I have of it, is a case not of vision or touch or imagination – nor has it ever been despite all appearances – but of purely mental scrutiny;'

Here we can see that Descartes is showing the importance of pure reason, and understanding over the senses and imagination as a source of knowledge.





Descartes claims that since all the properties of the wax that have changed our senses cannot explain our understanding of its identity, and neither can imagination. So it can only be 'rational intuition' that does enables us to see the wax as identical over time.

Meditation III

In this section of the handout we will consider Descartes 'trademark argument', for the existence of God and we will also see how he uses this argument to brush aside the evil demon hypothesis. It is only with the proof in the existence of God that Descartes can hope to push on with his project. In order to understand the trademark argument we need to investigate further Descartes theory of clear and distinct idea and his notion of degrees of reality.

Descartes has proved that he exists, which is important because he has found a point from which he can start to rebuild the edifice of knowledge that was put into doubt, however, in the third meditation he uses his discovery of rational intuition to go even further. This is important. Firstly, he has only proved that he is a thinking think, and with that, he believes that he has proved the importance of clear and distinct ideas, however, he needs to take this principle further.

Clear and distinct ideas as we have seen are ideas that are the foundation of intuition and therefore thought and knowledge. The reason that Descartes invests so much weight in clear and distinct ideas is that he thinks that the origin of our certainty is not found in psychological feelings about what is certain, but in the very contemplation of the idea itself, put another way, the contemplation of the idea *itself manifests that it is true.* For example, when I understand that 1+1=2 the truth of the proposition is manifest by counting and seeing the truth of the formula. It is true that I could for whatever reason forget, the truth of it and ask myself if it is true, however, when my mind is brought back to attend to the thought, I realise that it must be true and cannot be false, without contradiction. So clear and distinct ideas are true and can be known with certainty, although they can be doubted also. Descartes, therefore, along with the cogito sets down that

'…as a general rule…whatever I perceive very clearly and distinctly is true'.[4]

It is important to see that by 'perceive' Descartes means understanding. Descartes is not thinking of things in the world that we see clearly, but rather of concepts and ideas, that can simply be understood, like mathematical formula, numbers, shapes or concepts, like God or Mind.

Descartes very controversially and problematically also held to the Platonic and Christian idea that reality existed in degrees. In the context of his meditations it is very difficult to justify his use of the principle, however, without it, we will not be able to explain the trademark argument. What does it mean to think that existence is found in degrees? The claim can be best understood in one of two ways, either it is the claim that for something to exist, it must have some 'unity' or distinct 'coherence' that enables it to function, the other is to think of it as related to causation. Let us consider the these in order.

If we think of a country or a biological organism such as an animal, it can only really exist, if its key institutions/elements function. For example, a country that is wealthy with a strong legal and cultural tradition and no threats from its neighbours clearly exists. However, if a country through war, civil disorder, and the breakdown of institutions falls into enough chaos, we can say that the country in a very important sense, does not exist, or *it barley exists*. Its lack of unity and possible invasion by a violent neighbour puts its very existence into danger. We can apply the same idea to the health and functioning of an animal, and of course when animals die, perhaps frm disease and their organs disintegrate they can be thought to stop existing. It is for this reason that in the ancient world, people thought of chaos as the gateway to

[4] Descartes

annihilation. For Descartes that which has greatest unity and power is the which exists more.

Descartes also thought this was true of causation. He claimed that if there was always *as much reality or more reality* in the cause of an event, object, or an idea, than in the effect. For example, the sophistication of a computer is only a dim reflection of the sophistication found in company, people and intelligence that manufactured it. This controversial principle will play a key role in the trademark argument.

The trademark argument

Descartes puts the trademark argument in the following way, firstly, he claims that he finds within him a clear and distinct idea of God, and that the idea of God is of something perfect and infinite. Then he claims that although he can create ideas from himself, he is unable to create the idea of God, this is because the idea of God is about an infinite and perfect being, while he is an imperfect and finite being. (The degrees of reality principle rules out the possibility of the idea of God originating in him). Therefore, the cause of the idea of God must have as much reality as what it is a concept *of*. The only possible cause of the idea is God. This means that God must exist.

Refuting the evil demon hypothesis

Descartes thought that the existence of God was enough to rule out the possibility of massive deception. His argument is that since God is perfect, he cannot be a deceiver. Now although we can be deceived occasionally (God can allow a situation where we are deceived) he makes available the possibility for us to overcome our deception with our own resources. What God could not allow, because it would go against his nature, is a situation such as the evil demon hypothesis, whereby we would

be deceived to such an extent, that we could not in principle discover our deception. This would render God a deceiver because it would mean that his not acting sustained the massive deception that the evil demon was committing.

Is the argument for the existence of God circular?

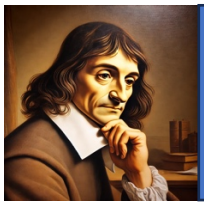
It did not take long for philosophers to find a problem with Descartes reasoning from clear and distinct ideas to God, and then to the reliability of clear and distinct ideas. Gassendi wrote that

> 'I note that a circular argument appears to have a beginning at this point, according to which you are certain that there must be a God and that he is not a deceiver on the grounds that you have a clear and distinct idea of him, and you are certain that a clear and distinct idea must be true of the ground that you know there is a God who cannot be a deceiver.'

Circular arguments are considered invalid because they assume the very thing that they were intending to prove. In this instance Gassendi is claiming that Descartes needs clear and distinct ideas to prove the existence of God and then God to guarantee the truth of clear and distinct ideas. If Gassendi is right, this argument would devastate Descartes project, and so we need to consider how Descartes responded to it.

There are several different ways to defend Descartes from this charge, we shall consider two of them.

(1) The memory answer.
(2) Certainty not knowledge argument



Descartes' argument for God, is not to show prove the validity of clear and distinct ideas, which he has already done, but to show that we are entitled to believe in our memory of them.

(1) The memory answer

It is important to remember that when Descartes explained the power of clear and distinct ideas, and the knowledge gained from them, for example our belief that 1+1=2, he was aware, that human imperfection and weak memory meant that it was possible to doubt a truth when the mind was not attending to it. The strength of clear and distinct ideas lies in the fact that *when we are attending to them*, they appear impossible to deny without contradiction. Descartes in his replies makes the point explicitly that his response is not to the defend the truth of clear and distinct ideas that are being considered, but to defend our trust in our *memory* of them. Which can be brought into doubt by the existence of the evil demon hypothesis. He writes,

> 'I announced in express terms that I referred only to the knowledge of those conclusions, the memory of which can recur when we are no longer attending to the reasons from which we deduced them.'

And again,

> 'For first we are sure that God exists because we are attending to the prods that establish this fact; but afterwards it is enough for us to remember that we have perceived something clearly, in order to be sure that it is true; but this would not suffice, unless we know that God existed and did not deceive us.'

So what Descartes is claiming here, is that the knowledge we gain from clear and distinct ideas is valid, but God needs to be used to sustain our trust in our memory, which means we can retain the discoveries of those truths.

(2) Certainty not knowledge

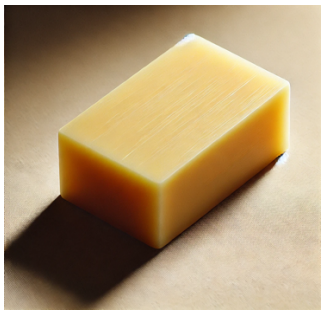
Another way to defend Descartes is to claim that he is not seeking absolute truth as such, but certainty regarding our beliefs and regarding science that grows from them. Perhaps Descartes was concerned to show the power and force of clear and distinct ideas and the fact that it removes doubt. The importance of proving the existence of God, is that is removes the possible doubt that can enter our thoughts regarding the reliability of our memory. If that is the case, the argument is not circular, because it is not trying to prove that clear and distinct ideas must be true, but that it is psychologically impossible to doubt them. It is also making the broader claim, that although you do not need to believe in God to know that 1+1=2 in order to know it for certain, in what Descartes calls a scientific way, you do need belief in God.

Meditations V and VI

In this section we consider Descartes rationalist argument for the existence of the external world. It is important to remember that Descartes has shown that we can rationally intuit the idea of substance by consideration of a changing piece of wax, and how the mind is able to use understanding to make sense of the idea that the same piece of wax has gone through several changes of properties. What Descartes has shown here is that the idea or concept of a substance is coherent and enables us to make sense of our experiences, but how does he go from this to show that it corresponds to something that is out in the world?

Descartes' proof is worked in two stages, firstly, he shows that the existence of physical substance is possible, because it is a coherent concept, and does not break the laws of logic. For Descartes if something is coherent then it is at least logically possible. He then argues that since his experience of physical objects is involuntary and not subject to his control then they must come from something outside him such as God or the world. Given that he has already proved that God is no deceiver, and he would be a deceiver if he caused us to have experience of physical objects that did not actually exist, then they must exist, therefore physical objects must exist. As we saw earlier the essence of a physical object is that it is extended in three dimensional space. Descartes is makes clear that objects may not exist exactly how we perceive them to, but they do possess properties such as extention that can be known with pure understanding.

> 'They may not all exist in a way that exactly corresponds with my sensory grasp of them, for in many cases the grasp of the senses is very obscure and confused. But at least they possess all the properties which I clearly and distinctly understand, that is all those which, viewed in general terms, are comprised within the subject matter of pure mathematics'.



A physical substance is that which stays the same through changes. That which does stay the same through changes is the extension and volume of the wax.

Further reading

1. Descartes Meditations: Gary Hartfield
2. Bernard Williams: Descartes project of pure inquiry.